AN ELITE INFANTRY FORMATION first established during World War II, the Special Air Service (SAS) has developed into the core of the British Army's special forces. Originally designed to carry out operations behind enemy lines in the context of a conventional war, it has also engaged in counterinsurgency campaigns against guerrilla forces and in counterterrorist operations, such as the highly publicized storming of the Iranian Embassy in London in 1980. The supreme professionalism of the SAS soldier is recognized worldwide.

The SAS took time to establish its permanent place in the British armed forces. Originally formed in North Africa in July 1941 to carry out raids behind Axis lines in the Desert War, it was disbanded at the end of World War II. The need for special forces to track and destroy guerrillas in the Malayan jungle saw that it was resurrected as part of the regular army in the 1950s. Further successful operations followed against rebels in the Arabian peninsula and Borneo. By the 1970s, the SAS had a firmly established reputation in military circles as a tough, efficient regiment that was likely to see a lot of active service. It was also known for having the hardest selection and training routine in the British Army.



SAS insignia
A winged Sword of Damocles is shown with the SAS motto: "Who Dares Wins".

RECRUITMENT AND TRAINING

SAS recruits are drawn from the regular army or from the regiment's own territorials. All candidates have thus already received at least basic military training before they present themselves for an SAS selection course. Volunteers, whether officers, NCOs, or other ranks, require a recommendation from their commanding officer. Men are attracted by the challenge of testing themselves to their mental and physical limits, as well as by the prestige of belonging to an elite formation. About 1 in 10 applicants fails at the first hurdle, which consists of a thorough medical check and a standard fitness test. The rest embark on a three-week initial selection course that is famous for its demands on physical and mental stamina.

Held in the Brecon Beacons, Wales, the course is conducted in a gentlemanly and civilized manner. Already serving soldiers thoroughly imbued with the basics of discipline, the men are set a series of tests of mounting difficulty in which they pit themselves against the elements and against their own limitations. Making long hikes alone across trackless terrain, burdened with a heavy pack and rifle, may seem a crude test of a man's worth, but those who have taken part testify to the extreme mental resolution required to cope with the effects of exhaustion, exposure, and isolation. Injuries are common, and on several occasions SAS trainees have died on the hills. By the end of the initial selection course, roughly 4 out of 5 candidates will have been rejected and returned to their units.

Counter-revolutionary warfare
An SAS hostage rescue team *(above)* storms a country house armed with MP5 submachine-guns fitted with maglites and wearing S10 respirators. The MP5, often used by the SAS, has several variants, including one equipped with a grenade launcher *(right)*.



H&K MP5K SUBMACHINE-GUN